Scientists Name the 'Chunkiest' Squid Relative Ever Found

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Two rare fossils from Wyoming have revealed a new kind of ancient squid relative that lived about 160 million years ago, during the **Jurassic Period**.

The animal has been named Wyoteuthis linsterorum. It was a **belemnite**, part of an **extinct** group of sea creatures related to today's squid and octopuses. **Belemnites** had a hard, bullet-shaped part inside their bodies called a **rostrum**. That part is often the only piece that becomes a fossil.

Belemnite fossils are very common. Wyoming's Sundance Formation, rock left behind by an ancient inland sea, has produced millions of them. Locals even nickname them squid butts. Most are narrow, about 5 to 10 centimeters long and only 1 to 2 centimeters wide.

The new **species** is very different. Its **rostrum** is about 10 centimeters long but about 6 centimeters wide, making it the thickest **belemnite** ever found. Scientists think the whole animal, including its arms, may have been about 60 centimeters, or two feet, long.

The first fossil was found in the late 1990s and sat in a museum drawer for years. In 2019, fossil collector Cliff Linster donated a second one to the Wyoming Dinosaur Center. With two fossils to compare, scientists could finally describe the new **species**.

Researchers from the United States, the United Kingdom and New Zealand used **CT scans** to look inside the fossils without damaging them. The scans showed it belonged to a **belemnite** family scientists thought had disappeared millions of years earlier.

Researcher Alexey Ippolitov suggests its large size may have helped it hunt smaller **belemnites**. The study was published in the journal Papers in Palaeontology.

Word Treasure

Jurassic Period -- A time in Earth's history, about 200 to 145 million years ago, when dinosaurs lived.

belemnite -- An extinct sea animal related to squid, known for a bullet-shaped hard part inside its body.

extinct -- No longer living anywhere on Earth.

rostrum -- The hard, bullet-shaped inner part of a belemnite that often becomes a fossil.

species -- A group of living things of the same kind that can have young together.

CT scans -- X-ray pictures taken from many angles to show the inside of an object in 3D.

Background you need

Fossils are the preserved remains or traces of living things from long ago, often found in rock.

Belemnites were sea animals related to squid that were very common in ancient oceans, so their hard inner parts are some of the most frequently found fossils.

Millions of years ago, a shallow sea covered parts of what is now the western United States, and its rocks in Wyoming hold many sea fossils.

Scientists describe a new species by comparing specimens with known ones and publishing their findings in a science journal.

Break it down

LEAD: Two Wyoming fossils reveal a new Jurassic squid relative
KEY FINDING: Wyoteuthis linsterorum has the thickest belemnite rostrum ever found
+- WHAT: Rostrum about 10 cm long and 6 cm wide; animal about 60 cm long
+- WHERE: Wyoming's Sundance Formation, left by an ancient inland sea
HISTORY: First fossil found in the late 1990s; second donated in 2019
EVIDENCE: CT scans linked it to a family thought to have vanished earlier
OPEN QUESTION: Did its large size help it hunt smaller belemnites?

Why it matters

Even a fossil group studied for a very long time can still surprise scientists. The find shows an animal family survived longer than experts believed.

Test what you remember

1. About how long ago did Wyoteuthis linsterorum live?

- (A) 1.6 million years ago
- (B) 160 million years ago
- (C) 1.6 billion years ago
- (D) 16,000 years ago

2. Which modern animals are belemnites related to?

- (A) Squid and octopuses
- (B) Crabs and lobsters
- (C) Turtles
- (D) Sharks and rays

3. What makes the new species special?

- (A) It is the longest belemnite ever
- (B) It lived in fresh water
- (C) It has the thickest rostrum of any belemnite found
- (D) It had no rostrum

4. How wide is the new species' rostrum?

- (A) About 1 centimeter
- (B) About 6 centimeters
- (C) About 60 centimeters
- (D) About 2 centimeters

5. Why could scientists finally describe the new species?

- (A) They found its eggs
- (B) They found a living one
- (C) A computer drew it
- (D) A second fossil was donated, so they had two to compare

6. What surprising link did the CT scans reveal?

- (A) It was a type of dinosaur
- (B) It belonged to a belemnite family thought to have disappeared millions of years earlier
- (C) It came from New Zealand
- (D) It was actually a fish

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: C 4: B 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Researcher Alexey Ippolitov: Suggests the animal's large size may have helped it hunt smaller belemnites.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):